

sshd_config Directives — Quick Reference

Explanation of each option from your /etc/ssh/sshd_config file

Session, Display & Connection Settings

X11DisplayOffset 10	First display number available for X11 forwarding (avoids clashing with local X servers).
X11UseLocalhost yes	Binds X11 forwarding listener to localhost only, for security.
PermitTTY yes	Allows allocation of a pseudo-terminal for sessions.
PrintMotd yes	Displays the Message of the Day (/etc/motd) after login.
PrintLastLog yes	Shows the date/time of the user's last login after authentication.
TCPKeepAlive yes	Sends TCP keepalive messages to detect dead connections/crashed clients.
PermitUserEnvironment no	Blocks users from setting environment vars via ~/.ssh/environment (security).
Compression delayed	Enables compression only after user authentication succeeds.
ClientAliveInterval 0	Seconds between server 'alive' checks to client; 0 disables this check.
ClientAliveCountMax 3	Max missed alive checks before server disconnects idle client.
UseDNS no	Skips reverse DNS lookups on connecting clients (faster logins).
PidFile /var/run/sshd.pid	Path where sshd stores its process ID.
MaxStartups 10:30:100	Unauthenticated connection throttling: start:rate%:full (10 allowed, 30% drop rate, 100 max).
PermitTunnel no	Disables tun-device forwarding (VPN-like tunneling) over SSH.
ChrootDirectory none	No chroot jail applied to sessions by default.
VersionAddendum none	No extra text appended to SSH server's version string.
Banner none	No pre-login banner file is displayed.

Subsystem & Per-User Match Block

Subsystem sftp ...	Enables the SFTP subsystem, pointing to the sftp-server binary for file transfers.
Match User anoncvs	Begins a conditional block applying only to the 'anoncvs' user.
X11Forwarding no	(In Match block) Disables X11 forwarding for matched user.
AllowTcpForwarding no	(In Match block) Disables TCP port forwarding for matched user.
PermitTTY no	(In Match block) Denies terminal allocation for matched user.
ForceCommand cvs server	(In Match block) Forces a specific command to run instead of user's shell.

Ciphers, Logging & Core Authentication

RekeyLimit default none	No forced re-keying based on data size/time; uses default limits.
SyslogFacility AUTH	Sends SSH log messages under the AUTH syslog facility.
LogLevel INFO	Sets verbosity of logging to informational level.
LoginGraceTime 2m	Time allowed to complete authentication before disconnecting (2 minutes).
PermitRootLogin no	Disallows direct root login via SSH.
StrictModes yes	Checks file/directory permissions before accepting login (security).
MaxAuthTries 3	Max number of authentication attempts per connection.
MaxSessions 10	Max number of open shell/login sessions per network connection.
PubkeyAuthentication yes	Enables public key-based authentication.
AuthorizedKeysFile ...	Specifies file(s) checked for a user's authorized public keys.
AuthorizedPrincipalsFile none	No separate principals file used for certificate-based auth.
AuthorizedKeysCommand none	No external command used to fetch authorized keys dynamically.
AuthorizedKeysCommandUser nobody	User account under which AuthorizedKeysCommand would run.
HostbasedAuthentication no	Disables host-based authentication (trusting client host identity).

Password, Kerberos & GSSAPI Authentication

IgnoreUserKnownHosts no	Server does trust ~/.ssh/known_hosts for host-based auth checks.
IgnoreRhosts yes	Ignores legacy ~/.rhosts and ~/.shosts trust files (security).
PasswordAuthentication no	Disables plain password logins; requires keys/other methods.
PermitEmptyPasswords no	Disallows accounts with blank passwords from logging in.
KbdInteractiveAuthentication yes	Enables challenge-response (keyboard-interactive) authentication.
KerberosAuthentication no	Disables Kerberos password authentication.
KerberosOrLocalPasswd yes	Falls back to local password if Kerberos fails.
KerberosTicketCleanup yes	Destroys user's Kerberos ticket cache on logout.
KerberosGetAFSToken no	Does not acquire an AFS token during Kerberos login.
KerberosUseKuserok yes	Uses .k5login file to map Kerberos principals to local users.
GSSAPIAuthentication no	Disables GSSAPI-based authentication.
GSSAPICleanupCredentials yes	Destroys GSSAPI credentials on logout.
GSSAPIStrictAcceptorCheck yes	Strictly verifies acceptor identity in GSSAPI exchanges.
GSSAPIKeyExchange no	Disables GSSAPI key exchange for session key setup.
GSSAPIEnableK5users no	Disables checking ~/.k5users for GSSAPI access control.

Note: A '#' prefix means the directive is commented out and using its default value. The ':qa' line is a Vim command to quit without saving, unrelated to SSH config.